

STAGE EIGHT • SOFT SKILLS

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Structured, live facilitation scripts for the FIRSTS that most need real interaction to land

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Eight • Soft Skills

PURPOSE

Stage Eight is different from most other stages in this series: nearly every FIRST here is already interpersonal by nature — you cannot genuinely practice active listening, conflict mediation, or networking entirely alone. Because of that, this document isn't about adding interactivity where there was none; it's about giving the FIRSTS that most need real structure to land well a fuller, more deliberate facilitation script than a simple “do this in pairs” note provides.

This document covers ten FIRSTS across all six sections of Stage Eight, selected specifically because a structured format, an observer role, a silent-start phase, a rotation, a fishbowl, genuinely changes the quality of what participants take away, compared to an unstructured version of the same activity.

Each entry includes a named format, timing, numbered steps you can read almost verbatim to a group, and a facilitator note explaining specifically why the structure matters here.

The Ten Structured Exercises

FIRST L1

Active Listening Exercise — Paraphrase Relay

TIME: 20 min

1. Pairs. Partner A talks for 2 minutes about a real, moderately complex topic (a recent challenge, a decision they're weighing).
2. Partner B may not respond with their own opinion — only paraphrase what they heard, then ask one genuine follow-up question.
3. Partner A confirms whether the paraphrase was accurate, correcting anything missed.
4. Swap roles and repeat with a new topic.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Banning advice-giving forces genuine listening rather than half-listening while planning a response — the exact habit this FIRST is trying to build.

FIRST L36

Listening Without Interrupting Challenge — Observed Timed Challenge

TIME: 20 min

1. Groups of 3: two conversation partners, one silent observer with a simple tally sheet.
2. Partners discuss a real, moderately opinionated topic (something they have a genuine view on) for 4 minutes.
3. Observer tallies every interruption, including well-intentioned ones.
4. Reveal the tally and discuss: were interruptions more frequent than expected?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Most people genuinely underestimate their own interruption frequency until someone tracks it — the observer role is what makes this exercise land rather than just being an intention stated in the abstract.

FIRST L21

Perspective-Taking Exercise — Side-Switch Debate

TIME: 25 min

1. Pairs. Assign a real, two-sided topic relevant to the group (facilitator-prepared, genuinely debatable, low-stakes).
2. Each person argues one side for 3 minutes.
3. Then swap: each person must now argue the opposite side they just heard, as genuinely and persuasively as they can.
4. Debrief: was the second round harder or easier than expected? What did arguing the other side reveal?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Being forced to genuinely argue the opposite side, not just listen to it, is what makes perspective-taking concrete rather than abstract.

FIRST L6

Feedback Received Gracefully — Feedback Fishbowl

TIME: 20 min

1. One volunteer sits in the center. 3–4 others give brief, genuine, specific feedback (positive or constructive) about something real — a recent presentation, a piece of work, a collaboration.
2. The center person's only job is to listen, not explain or defend, until everyone has spoken.
3. After all feedback is given, the center person can respond — but the group notices whether the response was genuinely receptive or defensive.
4. Rotate to a new volunteer if time allows.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The delay before responding is the whole point — it interrupts the instinct to immediately explain or defend, which is exactly the habit L6 is trying to build.

FIRST L35

Conflict Mediation Role Played — Triad Role-Play

TIME: 25 min

1. Groups of 3. Assign a realistic, low-stakes conflict scenario (facilitator-prepared) to two participants; the third mediates.
2. The two in conflict stay in character for 5 minutes while the mediator practices staying genuinely neutral, helping each side articulate their actual concern.
3. Debrief as a trio: did the mediator successfully avoid taking a side? What made it hard?
4. Rotate roles if time allows so each person experiences mediating.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Prepare 2–3 realistic conflict scenarios in advance rather than asking groups to invent one cold — improvised conflicts tend to be either too trivial or too personal.

FIRST L32

Collaborative Brainstorm — Silent-Start Brainstorm

TIME: 20 min

1. Small groups of 4–5. Give a real, genuine prompt relevant to the group's shared context.
2. First 3 minutes: everyone writes ideas silently and individually, no talking.
3. Next 10 minutes: share ideas aloud, explicitly banning judgment or evaluation during this phase — quantity over quality.
4. Final 5 minutes: as a group, identify the 2–3 strongest ideas together.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The silent-start phase prevents the most vocal person from anchoring the group's thinking before quieter members have even formed their own ideas — a small structural change with a real effect on idea diversity.

FIRST L42

Group Decision Facilitated — Consensus Check

TIME: 20 min

1. Small groups of 4–5. Present a real or realistic decision with genuine trade-offs (facilitator-prepared).
2. One person facilitates: gathers input from every member explicitly, not just the vocal ones.
3. Before finalizing, the facilitator asks directly: “does anyone have a concern we haven't addressed?” and waits for a real answer.
4. Debrief: did surfacing concerns explicitly change the final decision?

FACILITATOR NOTE

The explicit “any unaddressed concerns?” question is the specific skill being built here — without it, groups often mistake silence for agreement.

FIRST L12

Networking Conversation — Speed Networking Rounds

TIME: 20 min

1. Set up 3 rounds of 4-minute paired conversations, rotating partners each round.
2. Frame explicitly: the goal is genuine curiosity about the other person, not a rehearsed pitch about yourself.
3. After each round, take 30 seconds to jot down one genuinely interesting thing you learned about your partner.
4. Debrief: which round felt most like a real conversation rather than small talk?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Rotating partners quickly reveals whether someone's networking approach is genuinely curious or just a repeated script — a repeated script becomes obvious to the person using it by round three.

FIRST L46

Motivational Speech Practice — Speech Circle with Feedback

TIME: 25 min

1. Small groups of 3–4. Each person delivers a 90-second motivational speech grounded in a genuine personal story or conviction.
2. After each speech, the group gives exactly one piece of feedback: where did the energy and authenticity feel most genuine?
3. Speaker gets 30 seconds to revise one part based on the feedback, then the next person goes.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Keep feedback focused specifically on authenticity and energy, not content polish — that's the actual distinguishing skill this FIRST is building, separate from general presentation skills covered elsewhere in this section.

FIRST L27

Resilience Exercise — Peer-Supported Reframe Circle

TIME: 20 min

1. Small groups of 3. Each person briefly shares a real, moderate setback (not a major trauma — keep it appropriately scoped).
2. The other two listen, then each offers one genuine, specific question (not advice) that might help the person see a concrete next step.
3. The sharer identifies one real, concrete next step based on the conversation.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Keep this explicitly scoped to moderate setbacks, not major personal trauma — this is a skills-practice exercise, not group therapy, and the facilitator should redirect gently if something shared is too heavy for this format.